

has a library of about 49 songs that you can remix. Just load a song into the mixer from the song selector and you're ready to start. You can use your mouse as well as your keyboard to mix tracks. The controls on the mixer let you mix, mute or un-mute different elements of the song such as drums, keyboard or guitar or adjust and fade volume.

The Db-7x7 allows you to record and save your personal mix, but it doesn't record and save the music. When saving your mix, the Db-7x7 records only your slider movements and button pushes, and saves that information to a file (identifiable by the .dbm extension). You can share your mix only with other Db-7x7 users, which means that you wouldn't be able to play it on Winamp or other Media players. This is done to ensure that your mix is legal and you do not infringe any copyrights. You can either e-mail your mix or save it to the Web site's server for later use. While the Db-7x7 is great to start out with, if you need a mixer that packs more punch you should graduate to the other mixers, of which 7x7 Studio has the most control options.

Mixman's eMix (www.mixman.com/mixzone) is another popular online interactive remixer powered by the Beatnik player. Mixman has a good audio library with good quality tracks that you can remix legally. To get started with eMix, just click on a song from the library. You can listen to artist's remix or use the eMix to blend different elements of the songs to your satisfaction.

The basic eMix program lets you mix single tracks. Mixman also has software such as the Studio DL and a combination of software and audio hardware that lets you upload your own music files and mix a large number of tracks together. You can also use the Mixman audio software to play live with other musicians.

Just jamming

There are a handful of sites that let musicians and DJs jam online no matter where they're located. Budding musicians can also use the Web as a channel to promote their music and make the Net their stage.



Record, save and share your music mix using Db-7x7



Jamming live with Livejam 797

You can use Livejam 797 (www.ss7x7.com/mixers/livejam/jamming.asp) to jam with your friends online. All it needs is a shockwave plugin for Director 7 and a high-bandwidth connection. You'll have to ensure that ports 1626 and 1627 are open for TCP/IP so that you can connect to the Livejam server. Once you connect to the server, pick a style of music and a jam partner to get going. You can use Livejam to chat and keep track of other online jammers.

You can check out another experiment with remote jamming at <http://pd.klingt.org>. This remote jamming software enables up to 12 users spread over the Internet to collaboratively upload and manipulate one MP3-stream in real-time. Manipulated sounds are processed on the server and streamed immediately. The interface, however, isn't too great and you would definitely need a high-bandwidth connection to be able to jam online using this client.

The last note

While many companies are just beginning to make innovative use of applications and the Net to make music more interactive, there is a tremendous scope for developing tools that let users produce a wide range of music with almost no limit to the number of tracks they can mix online, add sound effects or voiceovers to mixes.

What's needed to help this area grow is for standards in audio technology to emerge where everyone can easily compose, mix and transfer music in formats which are compatible with the popular systems in the market today.

And of course, on the Web it's all about bandwidth, which is a limiting factor to the growth of online jamming. On a global-scale network, round-trip-delay times are too large and too variable for real interaction. Currently the focus is on creating applications that don't take ages to download, but they do compromise a bit on the audio quality.

It's difficult to predict what form interactive music will take in the future. But for now you can grab your mouse and keyboard and get ready to rock! 

Strike a Taal on your Keyboard

There are several sites for information on Indian music, but you can't really compose or remix Indian music online. However, there is software available that you can download and use to compose and mix Indian music.

www.swarsystems.com, which specialises in developing Indian music software, has two packages, SwarShala and TaalTrax.

SwarShala is an Indian music sequencer that covers both the melodic and rhythmic aspects of Indian music—*raag* and *taal*. The software, which runs on Windows 95/98/Me/2000 or Windows NT, comes packaged with five RaagWizard and TaalWizard bases and associated sound samples. Each base features a specific instrument and contains different musical sequences.

You can use SwarShala to create ragas or even add Indian music sequences and beats to create fusion music. It can also be used to create Wave and MIDI files. TaalTrax enables you to create realistic tracks of almost eight Indian instruments.

TaalMala (you can get it at www.taalmala.com) is a Windows-based Tabla accompaniment software for music enthusiasts and professionals, which can be used to construct and play almost any Taal on your keyboard.

You can download and try out the demo versions of SwarShala, Taaltrax and TaalMala but you would have to register the software and obtain the license in order to use its complete features.